FIELD GUIDE 03 · ATHLETICS & COACHING

EB-1A

for Athletes & Coaches

PODIUM TO PERMANENCE

A premium guide for elite competitors, coaches, and performance directors building a self-petitioned extraordinary ability case

AiVass

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CHAPTER
01

Athletics Is a Named Field

And the clock is the thing nobody tells you about.

Athletics is one of the five statutory fields in INA § 203(b)(1)(A) — equal in law to the sciences, arts, education, and business. Nothing in the regulation ranks them, and nothing requires an Olympic medal. The regulation's own language asks for **"lesser nationally or internationally recognized prizes or awards"** — the word **lesser** is doing deliberate work.

What the category offers an athletic career

- **Self-petition.** No club, federation, or employer sponsors you. You file your own Form I-140.
- **No job offer, no PERM.** The Policy Manual confirms an EB-1A petition "does not need to be supported by a job offer." No labor-market test.
- **Independence from a contract.** For athletes whose status is tied to a P-1 or O-1 held through a team, permanent residence ends the dependency — including through injury, trade, or retirement.
- **First preference.** Current for most countries, with premium processing available.

The clock nobody mentions

Every other field can build acclaim for decades. Athletics compresses it. Your peak is measurable, dated, and — for most disciplines — behind you by your mid-thirties. The regulation does not care about your age. But it does require **sustained** acclaim, and the Policy Manual instructs officers to ask whether you **"continue to maintain a comparable level of acclaim"** since the original recognition.

> **Strategy note — the two-window rule**
>
> Athletics petitions have two evidentiary windows. The peak window supplies the achievements. The recent window — roughly the last 24 months — supplies the proof they were sustained. A petition strong in the first and empty in the second is the classic athletics denial. Chapter 9 shows you how to fill the second window whether you are still competing, coaching, officiating, or advising.

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Who this guide is for

- Current professional and national-team athletes across all disciplines.
- Recently retired competitors, including those transitioning into coaching or sport administration.
- Head coaches, assistant coaches, and technical directors at national or top professional level.
- Performance directors, sports scientists, physiotherapists, and analysts embedded in elite programs.
- Referees, judges, and technical officials certified at international level.
- Athletes and coaches in emerging or non-Olympic sports — where proving national recognition takes extra work, and is entirely possible.

Who it is not for — yet

Strong club-level competition, age-group titles, and collegiate success are real achievements that generally sit **below** the national-acclaim line. You are not disqualified; you are early. Chapter 3 shows you exactly where the line sits, and Chapter 9 gives you a build plan.

> **The bottom line**
>
> Athletics is a named field with a compressed clock. The medals prove the peak. The last 24 months prove it was sustained. You need both.

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YOU'VE SEEN THE PREVIEW

Unlock the full EB-1A for Athletes & Coaches

This preview shows 5 of 45 pages. The complete guide gives you every criterion in depth, the evidence-mapping framework, the filing and fees breakdown, the expert annex, and the full self-assessment scorecard.

The full guide includes:

- Every one of the ten criteria, explained as USCIS actually applies them
- The evidence-mapping method: turn scattered achievements into proof
- A 30 / 90 / 180-day evidence sprint you can start today
- Filing, fees, and Visa Bulletin timing — with a dated snapshot
- The expert & B2B annex: intake, QC checklist, RFE risk register
- A scored self-assessment to know exactly where you stand

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